Reflection

Week 2 | Building a Website Made Me See Structure Everywhere

So this week in the workshop I actually tried to build my portfolio website, and honestly, the first hour was a mess. I thought HTML would be the hard part, but it was actually CSS that got me. I made a simple page with a heading, a navigation bar, and a few sections. The HTML looked fine. But when I opened it in the browser, the navigation bar was stuck to the left and the sections were all squashed together. I kept changing the padding and margins, and nothing worked properly. In the end I used the browser's inspect tool and realised I had misunderstood how the box model was working. It took me way longer than I expected just to get a basic layout that didn't look broken. That was a really small thing, but it made me realise that a website is not something that just "appears" — every bit of spacing and every position on the page is a decision someone made.

That experience connected directly to Gillespie's (2013) reading on the relevance of algorithms. Gillespie argues that algorithms are not neutral technical tools; they are encoded procedures that help decide what is relevant, and they produce "calculated publics." While I was building my site, I didn't have any algorithm, but I was still making relevance decisions. Which pages

go in the navigation? What goes on the homepage? What do I put first? Those choices guide what a visitor sees and what they might ignore. So even a small personal website is a kind of structure that shapes attention. This made me think differently about the workshop prompt, which asked me to pick a website I visit regularly and think about usability. I chose YouTube. It feels easy because search is clear and thumbnails are visual, but that ease is also algorithmic relevance — the platform is calculating what I might want to see. Lin's (2025) optional reading on Douyin users also reminded me that people don't just accept algorithmic curation; they negotiate and resist it. So for my own site, I want the structure to be clear enough that visitors can understand why things are where they are, instead of feeling like the layout is just random. Overall, this week made me see that building a website is not just a technical task. It is a small exercise in constructing relevance, and that is exactly what Gillespie is talking about at a much bigger scale.